their own CM? *'Agar aap kisi ko bhi haath lagaoge, toh mein chief minister ko complain karoonga!'* (If you touch anyone, I will complain to the chief minister), I said, trying to sound as angry as possible.

The gang wasn't willing to listen. *'Hamein chief minister se matlab nahi, aap log apna identity dikhao'* (We don't care about the chief minister. Show your identity cards). I showed my official press card and got my cameraperson Narendra to play a clip from the interview with Modi. 'Look,' I shouted, 'look at this interview. Can't you see we are journalists?' After fifteen tense minutes and after watching the tape, they seemed to calm down a bit and we were finally allowed to go. Our trembling driver Siraj was in tears. My own fear at a near-death experience was now replaced by a seething rage. If, just a few kilometres from the chief minister's house, Hindu militant gangs were roaming freely on the night of 2 March, then how could the chief minister claim the situation was under control? We were unnerved and visibly shaken. Images of those crazed faces and their shining weapons haunted me for days afterwards.

My coverage of the riots ruptured my relationship with Modi. Till that moment, we had been 'friends' (if journalists and netas can ever be friends!). We had freely exchanged views and would happily speak in Gujarati to each other, and he would regularly come on my shows. Now, a wariness crept in. As a politician who didn't appreciate any criticism, he saw me as emblematic of a hostile English-language media, and I always wondered if he had wilfully allowed the riots to simmer. A relationship based on mutual respect turned adversarial. He could not 'forgive' me for my riot reporting and I could never separate his politics from what I had seen in those bloody days. When my father passed away in 2007, Modi was the first politician to call and condole, but somehow the ghosts of 2002 would always haunt our equation.

With the benefit of hindsight, and more than a decade later, I have tried to rationalize the events of the 2002 riots. Was chief minister Modi really trying to stop the riots? Is the government claim that in the first three days of violence, sixty-two Hindus and forty Muslims were killed in police firing not proof enough that the Modi government was not allowing the rioters to